What Would Prompt Another Look?

Changes worth writing down while Mom is still managing on her own, with no interpreting.

Mom's situation is steady right now. Things shift a little at a time, though, and it's hard to tell which changes are worth writing down. This guide names fourteen kinds of change in her health, her household, her property and her finances and, for each, what to note.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What a change means for Medicaid is a question for your Medicaid planner or another professional who knows Mom's state, and a dated note is what makes that conversation useful. Where an item carries a source number, it falls in an area the federal long-term care pages or Medicaid.gov describe a state looking at. Which changes to watch for, and the wording about what to write down, are ours.

Health and daily life

1 What she does on her own [1]

NOTICE Everyday things she used to do herself and has handed off or stopped: the stairs, the driving, the cooking, the bath.

WRITE DOWN What changed and roughly when, in a line. Not what you think it means.

2 Help that has started arriving

NOTICE A neighbor who now brings in the groceries, a daughter who fills the pill box, a paid helper a few hours a week.

WRITE DOWN Who helps, with what, how often, and since when.

3 A hospital stay, a fall or a new diagnosis

NOTICE Any stay in a hospital or rehab, a fall, or a diagnosis that is new since your last note.

WRITE DOWN The date, the place, and what the doctor or the discharge papers said, in their words.

4 A conversation about care

NOTICE Her doctor mentions help at home, or Mom herself brings up moving or having someone come in.

WRITE DOWN Who said it, when, and as close to their words as you can get.

Household and home

5 Marriage and a spouse [4]

NOTICE A marriage, a separation, a divorce or a death, and any change in a spouse's own health or care.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and where the certificate or decree is kept.

6 A move, or a change in who lives with her [3]

NOTICE A move to another state, into senior housing or in with family, or someone moving into or out of her home.

WRITE DOWN The old and new address, the date, and who lives there now.

7 The deed and any loans on the house [2]

NOTICE A name added to or taken off the deed, a refinance, a new home equity loan, a sale or talk of selling.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and where the paper is. If it is only being discussed, write it as a question.

Money and accounts

8 Income [1]

NOTICE A pension or benefit that starts, stops or changes, and the yearly letters from Social Security or a pension office.

WRITE DOWN The source, what changed, and the amount as the letter states it.

9 Accounts, and the names on them [1]

NOTICE An account opened or closed, or a name added to or removed from one.

WRITE DOWN The institution, the kind of account, whose names are on it now, and the date it changed.

10 A balance that changed a lot [2]

NOTICE A large withdrawal, a big purchase, an inheritance or a sale that moved a balance well up or down.

WRITE DOWN The date, the account, and what the money was for or where it came from, with the receipt or statement if there is one.

11 Gifts and transfers [2] [5]

NOTICE Money or property given to family or anyone else, something sold to a relative, or a loan within the family, whether done or only talked about.

WRITE DOWN What it was, roughly when, who received it, and what paper exists. Ideas go down as questions, not plans.

12 Insurance, annuities and trusts [5] [3]

NOTICE A life insurance policy or an annuity bought, cashed in, changed or allowed to lapse, and a trust set up or changed.

WRITE DOWN The company or the trustee, what changed, the date, and where the document is kept.

Paper and what you hear

13 Mail about her benefits or coverage

NOTICE Letters from Social Security, Medicare, an insurer or a state agency that say something is changing or ask for a reply.

WRITE DOWN Who sent it, the date on it, and what it says or asks for, in its own words. Questions about it go to the office that sent it.

14 Something you heard about the rules [6]

NOTICE A news story, a friend's experience or a relative's “I heard” about how Medicaid works.

WRITE DOWN What was said, where it came from, and the question you'd ask to confirm it for Mom's state.

When a note is worth a conversation

Most of these can sit in the notebook until the next time you talk with a professional. A change someone is thinking of making is a little different from one that has already happened: if the family is considering a gift, a new name on an account or the deed, a sale or a new policy, bring it to your Medicaid planner as a question first, and take the legal side of it to an elder law attorney. A change in Mom's health goes to her doctor. There's no threshold to meet before you ask. If you're wondering whether a change matters, mention it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these changes mean, whether anything counts for Medicaid, or whether Mom would qualify for anything. It isn't legal, financial or tax advice. The professionals answer those questions, and they do it better with your dated notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You know which changes are worth writing down, and you have somewhere to put them. The planning interview gives those notes a use: it asks about your family's situation one part at a time and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid Eligibility
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Applying for Medicaid
3. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Eligibility Policy
4. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Spousal Impoverishment
5. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Glossary
6. National Institute on Aging, Paying for Long-Term Care